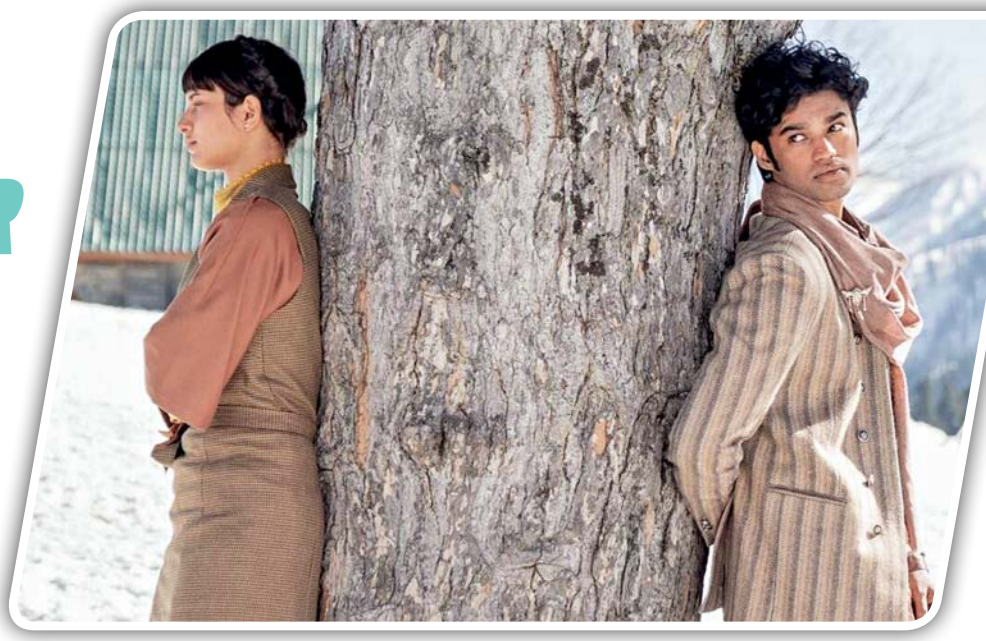
FILM

HER SCANNER DARKLY

BULBBUL WAS A START, BUT WITH _QALA_, ANVITA DUTT PUSHES THE ENVELOPE OF FEMALE AGENCY FURTHER



IN Anvita Dutt's second Netflix film, pursuing art is as much release as it is tragedy. With *Qala*, the writer-director-lyricist picks up where she left off. Like in *Bulbbul* (2020), the portraits she draws of her women are fascinating. Trapped in fabled settings, they are exploited by patriarchy, but still have the will to pursue their dream. "I don't do it deliberately. It so happens that the slightly surreal, otherworldly setting pops up when I am writing. It is my default setting," says Dutt. "I am trying to find the best possible way to communicate what I am feeling and sometimes it is best done through magic realism."

Played by Tripti Dimri, the titular character, Qala, is an enthusiastic heir to her family's rich musical legacy. Sadly, she struggles to win the support of her mother (Swastika Mukherjee). Though the key narrative device here is that of a fractured mother-daughter bond, the film highlights the emotional perils of pursuing excellence in art. In *Qala*, passion becomes ambition, then jealousy and guilt. The film feels almost like a darker sibling of *The Disciple* (2020), set against the backdrop of the Indian classical music world. Both dramas document the breakdown of artistes. One struggles to accept his limitations, the other yearns for validation.

Qala makes it hard not to think of female agency. "This is what I try to do. I draw attention to things that bother me, things that are relevant, and take it far back," says Dutt. "To most effectively do that, my protagonist has to scale a relentless wall." Qala wants to make it in the Hindi film music industry, but to do that, she must leave the protective shelter of home and live in a world of men. By transporting pertinent issues to a stylised period—in this case, the 1930s and '40s—Dutt reiterates that "nothing has changed".

Anvita Dutt's women characters are fascinating. They are exploited by patriarchy but still have the will to pursue their dreams

The film's gaze towards women isn't solely empathetic. The mother, for instance, is a complex, humane figure. For Dutt, it highlights "the conditioning and baggage" women carry. "The choices Urmila [Swastika's character] has made, the things she is hankering for... she knows that the *taaleem* [education] may be the same but women have to work that much harder than men," says Dutt. "It's about *izzat* [respect]. The struggle becomes a lot more manageable when she translates [her dreams] to a boy." Late actor Irrfan's son, Babil, makes his debut in *Qala*, playing the singer Urmila adores.

Qala's visual and aural landscape help illustrate its protagonist's internal journey. Dutt visualised Qala navigating two worlds: the "house of oppression", which has gothic undertones and referenced paintings of Rembrandt and Vermeer, and "the house of delirium", which drew inspiration from art nouveau and aimed to evoke a "feeling of oppression". The film's soundtrack, composed by Amit Trivedi and featuring works by five lyricists, says Dutt, forms "the internal soundtrack" of her female protagonist. As much as *Qala* aims to impress viewers with its imagery, music and design aesthetics, Dutt hopes that in the end, it'll lead to a conversation about a woman's struggle for acceptance. ■

Suhani Singh